

Reformation

1. The Reformation was another movement that the 16th century witnessed.
2. It was started by Martin Luther in Wittenburg, Germany in 1517 by publicly protesting against the sale of letters of Indulgence. (Indulgence : the letters which remitted punishments of the sinners who bought them and which began to be considered as passports to heaven.)
3. It was a revolt against the control of conscience by the priests.
4. Thanks to the inborn spirit of revolt against the Catholic Church, Henry VIII of England could take the bold step of breaking away from the papacy i.e., authority of the Pope on the issue of his first divorce in 1534. Henry VIII declared himself the head of the church when the Pope would not give him permission to divorce his wife, Catherine.
5. With the breaking away from the Roman Catholic Church by such leaders as Luther of Germany and Calvin of Switzerland, Western Europe was split between Catholic & Protestant countries, a situation which developed enmities of the fiercest nature.
6. The movement, which began within the Catholic Church to combat the effects of the Protestant Reformation, was known as Counter-Reformation Movement.